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Research Article

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Examining the Relationships between Internet Addiction, Social Appearance Anxiety, and Social Exclusion

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Abstract

The aim of the study is to reveal the predictive relationships between internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, and social exclusion among university students. The model of the research is the relational screening model. The study group consists of 516 university students, 429 female (83,1%) and 87 male (16,9%), studying in different faculties and departments. The participants are between the ages of 17 and 30, with an average age of 20,13. Data were collected using the “Young Internet Addiction Test – Short Form”, “Social Appearance Anxiety Scale” and “Social Exclusion Scale” measurement tools. When the findings obtained from the correlation analysis were examined, significance was found in the relationships between university students' internet addiction levels and social appearance anxiety, being ignored and excluded. Additionally, the relationship between social appearance anxiety and being ignored and exclusion was also positive and significant. According to the path analysis results, the being ignored dimension of social exclusion significantly predicted both social appearance anxiety and internet addiction. Social appearance anxiety positively and significantly predicted internet addiction. It was concluded that the model created between internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, being ignored, and being excluded demonstrated a good fit. The findings were discussed in relation to the literature.

Key Words

Internet addiction • Social appearance anxiety • Social exclusion • University students

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Introduction

With the advancement of technology, the internet has become an integral part of individuals' lives and is now used at all hours of the day. Thanks to its role in providing rapid access to information and services in various sectors such as education, healthcare, shopping, and entertainment, the internet is widely utilized. These data from the 2024 Turkish Statistical Institute (TÜİK) Household Information Technologies Survey clearly illustrate the prevalence of internet use. Among individuals aged 16–74, internet usage, which was 87,1% in 2023, increased to 88,8% in 2024 (Turkish Statistical Institute [TÜİK], 2024). While the internet facilitates various aspects of daily life, uncontrolled use can lead to negative consequences. Excessive and unregulated internet use may result in pathological internet use, increasing the risk of internet addiction (Balci & Gülnar, 2009). The internet, which is particularly widely used among young people, can have more pronounced negative effects on this demographic. As online spaces provide freedom and independence, young individuals primarily use the internet for social networking (Akar, 2017; Arnett, 2000). Frequent social media use can, in turn, have adverse effects on young people.

One such negative effect is the development of a poor body image, particularly among young individuals. Throughout life, individuals go through various developmental stages, each characterized by unique tasks, attributes, and needs. Adolescence, a period marked by rapid physical changes and transitions, is a critical period for body image, as young people may struggle to adapt to their rapidly changing bodies (Ekşi et al., 2016). In the emerging adulthood stage that follows adolescence, concerns about physical appearance persist.

The perception of an idealized body image portrayed on the internet can negatively impact young individuals who have not yet fully adapted to or accepted their own bodies. This, in turn, may result in social appearance anxiety. Hart et al. (2008) define social appearance anxiety as the fear of being negatively evaluated and criticized by others due to one's physical appearance. While social appearance anxiety can be a consequence of internet addiction, the relationship between these two variables is considered bidirectional. In other words, individuals experiencing social appearance anxiety may avoid face-to-face social interactions and prefer to socialize in virtual environments. This fear of social interactions can lead to social anxiety, which, in turn, may drive individuals toward social media as a means of communication (Çakmak, 2018). Consequently, this can contribute to excessive internet use.

An increase in internet addiction due to excessive and uncontrolled use poses a risk for individuals in terms of experiencing social appearance anxiety. Baltacı et al. (2021) reported that as internet addiction increases among university students, social appearance anxiety also rises. Additionally, Traş et al. (2019) found that social appearance anxiety, along with problematic internet use and a general sense of belonging, significantly predicts Facebook intensity. Similarly, Öztosun (2018) found that experiencing social exclusion influences internet addiction. However, research findings are inconsistent regarding whether an increase in internet addiction directly leads to higher social appearance anxiety.

Individuals with social anxiety disorder often fear societal criticism and judgment due to perceived flaws in their physical appearance (Carleton et al., 2007; Moscovitch, 2009). This anxiety related to physical appearance has been reported to have adverse effects on individuals' lives (Dindar & Akbulut, 2015). In their study, Alden and Taylor (2004) suggested that individuals experiencing social appearance anxiety tend to exhibit less authentic behavior due

to the possibility of being rejected by others. Similarly, [Park \(2007\)](#), in a study examining young adults' sensitivity to appearance and rejection, found that as sensitivity to appearance increased, individuals were more likely to feel rejected and lonely. Therefore, individuals with high levels of social appearance anxiety may isolate themselves from social environments.

By nature, humans are social beings who initiate and maintain relationships within society. Establishing meaningful, balanced, and lasting relationships with others is a fundamental psychological need, and when this need is unmet, it can lead to both psychological and physical distress ([Wesselmann et al., 2019](#)). Initially, individuals develop self-communication, which is essential for self-awareness and a sense of vitality. Subsequently, they strive to fulfill their need for social interactions ([Kağıtçıbaşı, 2010](#)). Individuals may, however, face situations where this need remains unmet.

Despite their efforts to establish social connections, individuals may experience isolation, rejection, or exclusion in social settings. Those who face such experiences are considered socially excluded. Social exclusion is defined as a state in which an individual is ignored, disregarded, or deprived of social connections by others ([Williams & Nida, 2011](#)). Social exclusion, which makes individuals feel less respected, less valued, and less accepted by others, is a widespread negative experience in daily life that significantly harms mental well-being ([Li et al., 2021](#)).

Social exclusion manifests when a person is completely ignored. Due to the ambiguity of this experience, individuals subjected to social exclusion may internalize the experience rather than attributing it to external factors, believing that it is related to their own characteristics ([Abayhan & Aydın, 2014](#)). The personalization of the cause of exclusion can make individuals more vulnerable to various psychological difficulties. These difficulties include loneliness, social anxiety, low self-esteem, and helplessness ([Riva et al., 2017](#)). [Akin et al. \(2016\)](#) suggested that experiencing social exclusion can lead to psychological problems and maladaptive behaviors, including social anxiety in social environments.

The present study aims to examine the relationships among internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, and social exclusion through structural equation modeling. A literature review reveals that no study has simultaneously examined these three variables. In this regard, the study is expected to provide significant contributions to both the field and the existing literature.

Method

Research Design

This study was designed using the relational survey model. The relational survey model is a research method used to examine the presence and strength of relationships between two or more variables ([Büyükoztürk et al., 2016](#)). The study variables include internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, being ignored, and exclusion.

Study Group

The dataset, completed by a total of 520 university students from different departments during the 2023–2024 academic year via an online form, was examined. To detect outliers, Mahalanobis distance values were calculated,

and four cases identified as outliers were removed from the study group. As a result, data from 516 university students were included in the analysis. The final study group comprised 516 students: 429 women (83,1%) and 87 men (16,9%). Participants were between the ages of 17 and 30, and the average age was 20.13.

Data Collection Tools

Young's Internet Addiction Test – Short Form. This scale was adapted into Turkish by [Kutlu et al. \(2016\)](#) and consists of 12 items scored on a five-point Likert scale. The scale has a one-dimensional structure. The internal consistency coefficient for the total scale was reported as .91 among university students, whereas it was calculated as .88 in the present study. The item factor loadings of the scale calculated for the current study range from .48 to .90. Item factor loadings of .30 and above indicate that the representativeness of the items in the scale is high and consistent ([Büyüköztürk, 2004](#)). The KMO (Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin) value calculated for this study, which indicates the suitability of the sample for the application, is .90. This value is expected to be above .60 ([Gürbüz & Şahin, 2015](#)). The CFA (Confirmatory Factor Analysis) results calculated for this study show that the goodness of fit values obtained ($\chi^2/df=3.936$, RMSEA=.08, RMR=.07, GFI=.94, AGFI=.90, CFI=.93 and IFI=.93) are within the limits of fit ([Karagöz, 2019](#)). These values obtained show that the validity and reliability of the scale for the current study were ensured.

Social Appearance Anxiety Scale. Originally developed by [Hart et al. \(2008\)](#) and adapted into Turkish with validity and reliability studies conducted by [Doğan \(2010\)](#), this scale consists of 16 items and has a one-dimensional structure. It is rated on a five-point Likert scale. The internal consistency coefficient for the total scale was reported as .93, while it was calculated as .90 in the present study. The item factor loadings calculated for this study ranged from .54 to .89. These values being .50 and above indicate that construct validity was achieved ([Karagöz, 2019](#)). According to the CFA results, the model fit values are ($\chi^2/df=3.797$, RMSEA=.07, RMR=.05, GFI=.91, AGFI=.88, CFI=.96 and IFI=.96) and are within acceptable limits ([Karagöz, 2019](#)). The calculated KMO value was found to be .96, which is above .60, indicating that the sample was suitable for the research ([Gürbüz & Şahin, 2015](#)). These values obtained show that the validity and reliability of the scale for the current study were ensured.

Social Exclusion Scale. This scale was validated and adapted into Turkish by [Sertelin-Mercan \(2016\)](#). It consists of two sub-dimensions with a total of 11 items, rated on a five-point Likert scale. The first sub-dimension, being ignored, comprises five items, while the second sub-dimension, exclusion, consists of six items. The internal consistency coefficient for the total scale was reported to range between .75 and .83. The internal consistency coefficients for the sub-dimensions were .82 for being ignored and .83 for exclusion. In the present study, the internal consistency coefficients were calculated as .88 for the total scale, .90 for the being ignored sub-dimension, and .87 for the exclusion sub-dimension. The item factor loadings calculated for the current study were between .71 and .91, and the KMO value was found to be .87. Item factor loadings of .50 and above indicate that construct validity is achieved ([Karagöz, 2019](#)). KMO value above .60 indicates that the sample is suitable for the study ([Gürbüz & Şahin, 2015](#)). In addition, CFA results show that the goodness of fit values ($\chi^2/df=2,490$, RMSEA=.05, RMR=.06, GFI=.97, AGFI=.94, CFI=.98 and IFI=.98) are within the limits of fit ([Karagöz, 2019](#)). These values obtained show that the validity and reliability of the scale for the current study were ensured.

Data Analysis

For data analysis, IBM SPSS 26 was used to conduct a correlation analysis to examine the relationships between variables. Subsequently, path analysis was performed using AMOS 22. Path analysis is a technique that enables the examination of total, direct, and indirect effects between observed and latent variables (Karagöz, 2019). The present study included the latent variables of internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, being ignored, and exclusion.

Results

After identifying and removing outliers from the dataset, normality distribution, skewness, and kurtosis values were calculated before conducting the correlation analysis. The obtained values are presented in Table 1.

Table 1

Statistics and normality analysis results

Scales	N	Mean	Standard Deviation	Skewness	Kurtosis
YIAT-SF	516	2.32	.71	.44	-.19
SAAS	516	2.22	.90	.74	.03
SES	516	2.46	.48	-.23	.45

YIAT-SF: Young Internet Addiction Test – Short Form, SAAS: Social Appearance Anxiety Scale, SES: Social Exclusion Scale

Table 1 provides information on skewness and kurtosis values. The obtained values indicate that the skewness and kurtosis values are within the acceptable range. This suggests that the data exhibit a normal distribution. A skewness and kurtosis range of ± 1.5 is considered an acceptable criterion for normality (Tabachnick et al., 2013).

Table 2

Relationships between YIAT-SF, SAAS, and SES (Pearson Correlation Coefficient)

Variables	YIAT-SF	SAAS	Being Ignored	Exclusion
YIAT-SF	1	.41***	.46***	.11*
SAAS		1	.53***	.26***
SES				
1. Being Ignored			1	.40***
2. Exclusion				1

*p < .001***, p < .05* YIAT-SF: Young Internet Addiction Test – Short Form SAAS: Social Appearance Anxiety Scale, SES: Social Exclusion Scale*

Looking at the values in Table 2, the significance of the relationship between university students' internet addiction levels and social appearance anxiety was tested, and a significant positive relationship was found ($r = .41, p < .01$). A positive and significant relationship was also found between internet addiction and the “being ignored” sub-dimension of the social exclusion scale ($r = .46, p < .01$). However, the relationship between internet addiction and the “exclusion” sub-dimension of the social exclusion scale was positive but weakly significant ($r = .11, p < .05$).

A positive and significant relationship was also found between social appearance anxiety and the sub-dimensions of social exclusion, namely “being ignored” ($r = .53, p < .01$) and “exclusion” ($r = .26, p < .01$).

It is well-known that path analysis conducted with latent variables provides more reliable results than path analysis performed with observed variables (Karagöz, 2019). To obtain more reliable results, the path analysis in our study was conducted using latent variables. The fit indices of the model created for path analysis among internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, exclusion, and being ignored were calculated as $\chi^2/sd = 2.53$, RMSEA = .05, SRMR = .06, CFI = .93, TLI = .92, GFI = .85, and IFI = .93. These values fall within acceptable fit thresholds, indicating that the model is acceptable (Byrne, 2016; Gürbüz, 2019; Karagöz, 2019; Kline, 2015). The fit indices of the tested model are presented in Table 3.

Table 3

Fit indices of the tested model

Fit Indices	Model	Acceptable Fit
χ^2/sd	2.529	0-3
RMSEA	.05	$.00 \leq RMSEA \leq .05$
SRMR	.06	$.05 \leq SRMR \leq .08$
CFI	.93	$.90 \leq CFI \leq .95$
TLI	.92	$.90 \leq TLI \leq .95$
GFI	.85	$.85 \leq GFI \leq .95$
IFI	.93	$.90 \leq IFI \leq .95$

Upon examining the values presented in Table 3, it can be seen that the obtained values fall within the acceptable fit limits. This indicates that the model established between internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, exclusion, and being ignored variables is acceptable. The beta coefficients obtained from the path analysis and the established model are presented in Figure 1.

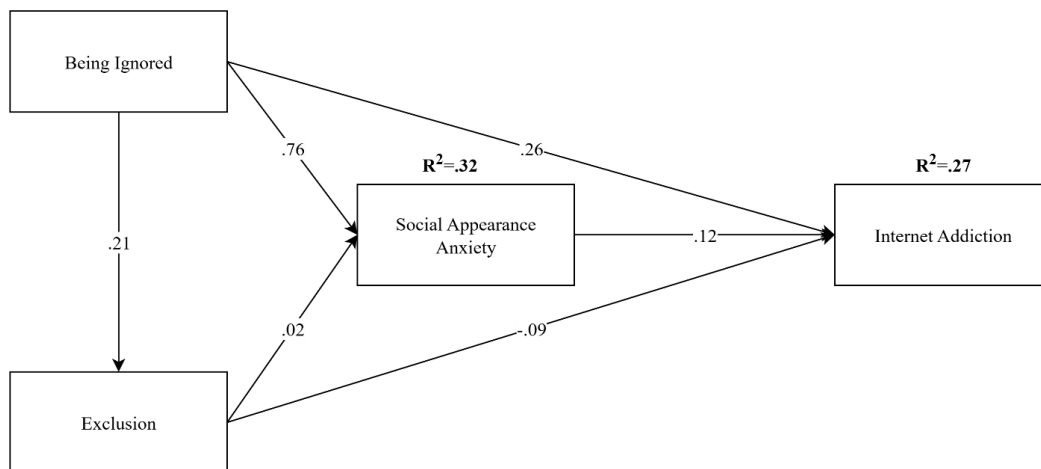


Figure 1. Path analysis of the relationships between internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, exclusion, and being ignored variables

Table 4

Path analysis coefficients for the variables

Predictor		Outcome	β	Indirect Effect	S.E.	t Value
Internet Addiction	←	Social Appearance Anxiety	.12	.000	.030	4.131***
Internet Addiction	←	Being Ignored	.26	.091	.048	5.481***
Internet Addiction	←	Exclusion	-.09	.002	.044	1.937*
Social Appearance Anxiety	←	Being Ignored	.76	.000	.073	10.362***
Social Appearance Anxiety	←	Exclusion	.02	.000	.078	.235

p < .05 p < .001***, S.E.: Standard Error, β : Direct Effect*

According to the results of the path analysis, it was found that the “being ignored” dimension of social exclusion significantly predicted both social appearance anxiety ($\beta = .76$, $p < .01$) and internet addiction ($\beta = .26$, $p < .01$). The “exclusion” dimension of social exclusion had a limited effect on social appearance anxiety ($\beta = .02$, $p < .05$) and internet addiction ($\beta = -.09$, $p < .05$). Social appearance anxiety was found to significantly predict internet addiction positively ($\beta = .12$, $p < .05$). The combined dimensions of being ignored and exclusion explained 32% of the total variance in social appearance anxiety. Both the “being ignored” and “exclusion” dimensions of social exclusion, along with social appearance anxiety, explained 27% of the total variance in internet addiction. Moreover, the “being ignored” dimension showed a limited indirect effect ($\beta = .09$) on internet addiction through social appearance anxiety.

Discussion, Conclusion, and Suggestions

The study aimed to identify the predictive relationships between internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, and social exclusion in university students. The correlation analysis showed a significant and positive relationship between the students’ levels of being ignored and exclusion with their levels of social appearance anxiety and internet addiction. Additionally, a positive and significant relationship between internet addiction and social appearance anxiety was observed. The path analysis indicated that the “being ignored” dimension of social exclusion significantly predicted both social appearance anxiety and internet addiction. However, the “exclusion” dimension of social exclusion had a limited predictive effect on both social appearance anxiety ($\beta = .02$, $p < .05$) and internet addiction ($\beta = -.09$, $p < .05$). Social appearance anxiety was found to significantly predict internet addiction ($\beta = .12$, $p < .05$). The combined dimensions of being ignored and exclusion explained 32% of the total variance in social appearance anxiety, while these dimensions, together with social appearance anxiety, explained 27% of the total variance in internet addiction. Moreover, it was observed that the “being ignored” dimension had a limited indirect effect ($\beta = .09$) on internet addiction via social appearance anxiety.

Numerous studies investigating the relationship between social appearance anxiety and internet addiction have found that the two variables are significantly correlated. As social appearance anxiety increases, the risk of internet addiction also rises (Baltacı et al., 2021; Lim, 2019; Poon, 2018). Individuals with social appearance anxiety tend to avoid social environments and use virtual environments as a means of socializing. This coping mechanism, in turn,

can lead to problematic internet use and potentially internet addiction. Studies related to this topic indicate that as social appearance anxiety increases, social media addiction levels also increase (Işık, 2019; Özer & Güzel, 2023). Şengönül and Aydın (2023) also pointed out that as the time spent on social media platforms increases, social appearance anxiety changes accordingly. Traş and Gökçen (2020) noted that as social anxiety levels rise, internet addiction also increases. The findings of these studies are consistent with the current research results.

A review of previous studies reveals that there are studies indicating a significant relationship between social appearance anxiety and social exclusion (Aktaş, 2020). As levels of being ignored and excluded increase, individuals experience higher levels of social appearance anxiety, along with a heightened fear of negative evaluation. This plays a role in the emergence of social appearance anxiety. Similar findings in the literature support the results of the present study.

When examining the relationships between internet addiction and the dimensions of social exclusion (being ignored and exclusion), it was found that as being ignored and exclusion increased, internet addiction also increased. Individuals who are ignored attempt to meet their socializing needs through the internet, which can lead to uncontrolled use. Öztosun (2018) found that social exclusion significantly predicted internet addiction in adolescents. Similar results in the literature (Arslan & Coşkun, 2022) also support the research findings. When examining the predictive power of social exclusion on internet addiction through social appearance anxiety, it is observed that as the level of being ignored increases, social appearance anxiety also rises, leading to an increase in internet addiction. Social exclusion also predicts internet addiction through social appearance anxiety.

This study is limited to university students. Future studies could explore the same variables in adolescents, a group facing significant body changes during puberty, which may lead to various challenges. Additionally, this study focused on internet addiction, social exclusion, and social appearance anxiety. Future studies could explore the relationship between these variables and others, such as social media addiction, Instagram addiction, smartphone addiction, and compulsive online shopping addiction. The relationship between these types of behavioral addictions and other variables could also be investigated. Moreover, a qualitative study on similar variables may provide further insights and contribute to the field.

This study found positive relationships between internet addiction, social appearance anxiety, and social exclusion. Social exclusion plays a significant role in both social appearance anxiety and internet addiction. Individuals who are ignored or excluded in social environments may internalize this experience and suffer from damaged self-esteem, which can lead to the development of negative perceptions about their own appearance. This social appearance anxiety may lead to a fear of negative evaluation, exclusion, rejection, being ignored, and other similar experiences. As a result, individuals may become reluctant to enter social environments and attempt to fulfill their socializing needs on different platforms, one of which is the internet. This can lead to prolonged internet use and potentially uncontrolled behavior, contributing to internet addiction. To prevent these issues, professionals working in this field should focus on raising awareness through individual and group interventions that address social exclusion, social appearance anxiety, and internet addiction.

Ethic

This study was conducted according to the decision of Yozgat Bozok University Social and Human Sciences Ethics Committee dated 19.09.2024 and numbered 17/54.

Author Contributions

The study was conducted collaboratively and the authors contributed to the entire work.

Conflict of Interest

There was no conflict of interest with any institution or person within the scope of the study.

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Notes

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